

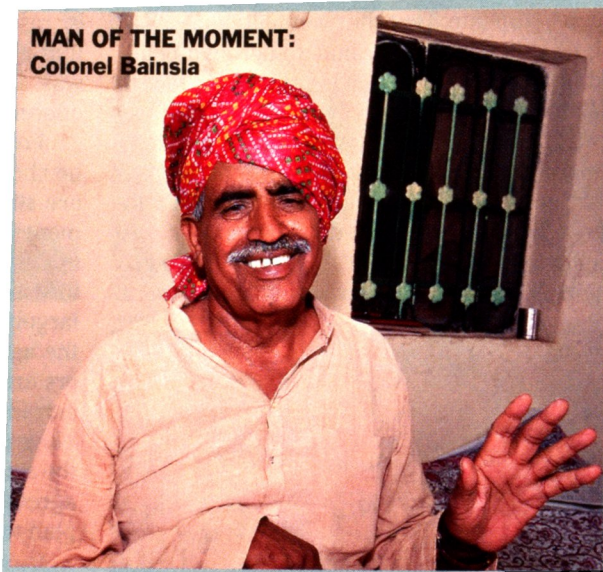
# THE COLONEL'S COLOURS

An insight into the man who holds the key to Rajasthan's caste tension

**T**ill last week, he was relatively unknown. Now, thanks to the Gurjar riots, Colonel Kirori Singh Bainsla has become a household name. He has single-handedly doused the fires that raged in Rajasthan and neighbouring states by his acceptance of the peace formula, and acquired the image of a balanced leader, a hero for the common Gurjar and enemy number one for the powerful Meena community. "I did not think about victory but national interest preceded any impulsive reaction," he said after the agreement with Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje.

Yet, to many in Rajasthan, Bainsla, 67, has a dual personality: one, the sophisticated retired army officer, fluent in English, oriented to academic research and a voracious reader. Then there is the other, surrounded by illiterate villagers and maintaining a rapport with them through rustic wit. He is a vegetarian and teetotaler, and a fan of old Hindi films. His heroes are Golda Meir, the late Israeli prime minister, and Sardar Patel. He has no political past and leadership of the community came because the Gurjars wanted an educated man to fight for their cause. Bainsla started life as an English schoolteacher, one of the few to have graduated from his village Moodia. He joined the army as a sepoy and rose through the ranks to retire as a lieutenant colonel. In his personal

MAN OF THE MOMENT:  
Colonel Bainsla



"During the talks, I did not think about victory at all. For me, it was national interest, that superseded any impulsive reaction to events."

life, he is a simple man. Three of his four children were born in the village and now two are army officers. His only daughter is in the Indian Revenue Service, one son is an executive with Hutch. Retired in 1991, he retained his village house but settled at Hindon, a small town a few kilometres away. Since then, Bainsla has devoted time and energy to doing something for his community which, apart from producing soldiers, is oth-

erwise mostly illiterate and backward. Five years ago, he began his crusade to build up a case for Scheduled Tribe (ST) status for the community. He was worried about the growing influence of the Meenas. He became convinced that ST status was the only way to prevent a near elimination of Gurjars from the region.

He started by organising a cultural festival of Gurjars in Karauli three years ago. He then contacted panchayats, getting their approval to start a campaign to get ST status.

Realising that a Gandhian approach was getting nowhere, he raised the ante, organising a demonstration at Hindon where the Gurjars ransacked a small railway station. The state sat up and set up a committee of ministers to look into the Gurjar demand. Bainsla expanded his base, moving out of the district to drum up support. Most Gurjar panchayats backed him.

The flashpoint came when he learnt that district collectors were sending reports that diluted the Gurjars' claim to ST status. Suspecting that the powerful Meena lobby were manipulating the reports, he rallied most of Gurjar males in the state in open revolt. He declared a ceasefire in the belief that the agitation would have strengthened the community's claims. In the bargain, he has emerged as a leader to be reckoned with.

state. Whether that can be averted by the state government is open to question. The crisis exposed the fact that the administration is not equipped to respond effectively to such situations. Raje knows she is expected to deal with incompetence at both political and administrative levels which is why she is playing down her victory. Instead, she is sending personal condolence mes-

sages to everyone killed in the agitation. She knows that in the days to come, she will have to face more dissident threats and rivals who will continue to provoke Gurjar leaders to keep the issue alive.

She also knows that more castes will be joining in the demands: already, the Raikas and Rabaris and the Namads have begun protests demand-

ing ST status. There is also the tricky question of a murder case having been filed against Bainsla. However, by not giving Bainsla any official letter and even diluting issues that some BJP leaders had asked her to agree on to bring an end to the violence, she has displayed tremendous courage and political savvy. For that alone, she deserves a royal salute. ■